

uments that are based on that template. Macros stored in the default template (for example, Normal.dot for Word) are always available while the application is open, irrespective of where and from what template the file is created. These robots can also be shared with other users, either by sending them the file containing the macros, or by saving the macros to a separate script file.

You can use macros for virtually any task in an application, such as formatting, styling, replacing text, printing, sorting, filtering, etc. If you are comfortable with scripting, you can even stretch the functionality of the application to do tasks that are not readily available in the software. For example, many dotcoms and content management systems use macros to automatically generate XML from Word documents. The XML documents can be directly uploaded to their Web site. Thus, converting existing content is just a matter of opening a document and clicking a button. Also, writers can continue writing in the comfortable Word environment, instead of having to work with clunky HTML forms.

Recording macros

To begin with, we'll use Word. Before you start you need to decide where you want to save the macro—in the document or in a template. If you want to save the macro in a template other than the default template, a document based on that template or the template itself must be open.

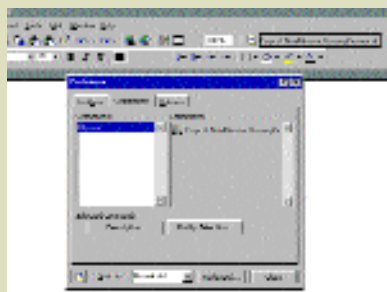
Plan the steps you want the macro to perform. List them down if required. A macro will perform each and every recorded action, exactly as it is executed, so this is important. If you make an error while recording a macro, the error and corrections will also be recorded. If you are comfortable with scripting, you can edit the macro later to remove the extra lines of code, otherwise it is best to start over.

If you want to use the macro in other documents, ensure that it does not depend on the current document's contents. If you record a macro to embolden and italicise some text in the document, Word will assume that it has to stylise whatever text is currently selected. If you need to stylise a particular string in several documents, it would be better to use the Find function to find that text, then stylise it, so that the Find action is also recorded and only the matching text will be formatted.

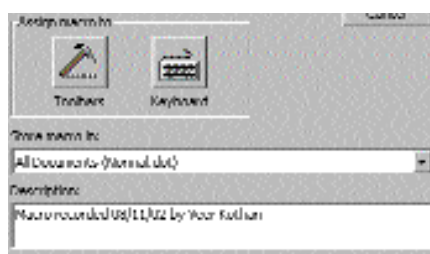
To record a macro, click **Tools > Macro > Record New Macro**. Alternatively you can click the area marked REC on the status bar.

One-click Fix

Assigning macros to toolbar buttons or keyboard shortcuts makes it very convenient to access them. One way to assign these shortcuts is when creating the macro itself—just click the relevant button. If you click the Toolbars button, you will see the



Assigning macros to toolbar buttons



Name your macro and choose where it should be saved

You will be asked for a name for the macro and where it should be stored. You can also enter a description for the macro and assign it to a toolbar or keyboard shortcut (see box, 'One-click Fix'). Click OK and Word will record every action henceforth. It will also show the Stop Recording toolbar, from where you can pause or stop recording the macro. Click the Stop Recording button once you are done. It is best to undo all the steps you recorded in the macro, then run the macro to test it. Next, test the macro with another similar document if you intend to use it across documents. You are now ready to use the macro and let it do all the tedious, time-consuming work for you.

To use a macro, click **Tools > Macro > Macros**. From here, you can run, delete, edit and debug macros. Editing and debugging will require at least basic knowledge of VBA. You can also copy macros across documents and templates by click-

ing the Organizer button. If you have assigned a toolbar button or keyboard shortcut to the macro (see box, 'One-click Fix'), you can also use these to run the macro.

If you click the Keyboard button, simply type in the key-combination that you want to assign to it. If the combination is currently assigned to some other action, it will be displayed. Make sure you check this before clicking Assign—you may not want to override one of the existing keyboard shortcuts.

Another way to assign macros to toolbar buttons and keyboard shortcuts is to right-click on any toolbar and click Customize. Click the Keyboard button to assign a keyboard shortcut, or select Macros in the left pane and drag the relevant macro to any toolbar.

ing the Organizer button. If you have assigned a toolbar button or keyboard shortcut to the macro (see box, 'One-click Fix'), you can also use these to run the macro.

If you want to save a macro to an external file, say, to distribute it to all the regional offices, open **Tools > Macro > Visual Basic Editor**. On the left pane, you will see the templates and documents that are open. Double-click each item to open the code stored in it. Locate the code you want to save, right-click the module on the left pane, and click **File > Export**. The recipient would have to follow a similar procedure to import the code. However, it is easier to simply send over a document or template containing the macros and use the Organizer to copy the required macros.

Removing unwanted text in Word

When you get Word documents from several sources, or even when you collect information from the Web, you may get a lot of junk that you spend hours cleaning. The most typical replacements are for double spaces, multiple paragraph marks, manual line breaks, acronyms, etc. Let's create a macro to remove these from the document and apply some formatting to the text.

To list out all the steps, we want to Find and Replace all double spaces with single spaces (doing this several times over will take care of multiple spaces), then do the same for paragraph marks and remove manual line breaks. Next, we will replace '&' with 'and',



When you record a macro with a name that already exists, the existing one will be overwritten without warning